WE LIVE IN THE (ALMOST) GOLDEN AGE OF SEXUAL WELLNESS. Sure, sex toys and paraphernalia have been around for aeons, but until very recently, they existed only in the underbelly of society: the black markets, shady alleys and garish sex toy shops where you would avert your gaze from fellow shoppers. While humans have innovated and experimented with creating instruments to explore their bodies probably for as long as humans have lived, sex (and, moreover, *pleasure*) is still a topic reserved for lowered voices and closed doors. And often accompanied by a healthy dose of shame.

But this is quickly changing. The increased openness and shifting attitudes around sexual wellness across the world are clearly linked to the rise of the internet, social media, and OTT content. While on the one hand, the internet has made pornography ubiquitous, it has also undeniably increased access to education, resources, and discourse around sex and sexuality. In the US, 84 per cent of adults now say that masturbation is a form of self-care, according to a study published in 2020 by TENGA, a sexual wellness brand for men. Also, per a 2022 report by *The Economist*, mentions of the phrase 'sexual wellness' grew six-fold on Twitter between 2018 and 2021.

PLEASURE ACCESSORIES TODAY CAN LOOK AS SLEEK AND CHIC AS APPLE PRODUCTS

As technology has evolved in recent years, the larger category of sexual wellness and devices has evolved too. Pleasure accessories today can look as sleek as Apple products, and are now taking pride of place in stores right next to high-end luxury and lifestyle goods. Numerous news reports have also highlighted how the Covid-19 lockdowns saw a surge in consumers using sextech apps and products—and this has continued post-pandemic.

In India, attitudes, sensitivities and generational thinking around sex and intimacy vary as wildly across segments as the cuisine from each part of our culturally rich country. When my partner and I were thinking about launching our sexual wellness brand MyMuse back in 2020, our first question was—"Are Indians ready for this?" We conducted in-depth qualitative and quantitative studies, and saw clear patterns.

In our survey of over 20,000 people across the country, one of the biggest surprises was that 44 per cent were already using products *other* than contraceptives in their intimate lives. What wasn't surprising were the endless complaints about quality and accessibility. And of the remaining 56 per cent of folks that hadn't used products in the bedroom before, eight out of 10 people said they were curious and willing to try. It was clear that India was ready for change.

I was initially afraid of the reaction, more from extended friends and family than from strangers. But we have been blessed to receive incredible support from those near and far. The most common response we hear is, "Thank god something like this finally exists in India!" At MyMuse, our customers range from men, women, and those across the binary, from the ages of 21 to 50+. Our massagers remain our bestsellers, indicating that Indians across the spectrum are eager to experiment in the bedroom. We believe that intimacy is universal, so we have strived to build a brand that to its core is inclusive and deeply approachable. A brand that celebrates intimacy, rather than shying away from it.

In a time where our digital worlds and physical worlds are inseparable, with an endless stream of likes, clicks and options at our fingertips, it's easier than ever to feel isolated and disconnected. So in 2023, self-care is no longer a buzzword: it's a necessity. Today, people are more acutely aware of their needs, and are searching for ways to make true connection and intimacy a priority. While we still have a long way to go in smashing taboos and unlearning deeply conditioned stereotypes around sex, we're coming closer to an age where people are accepting and ready to talk about how sexual wellness is inextricably tied to our mental, physical and holistic wellbeing. Both on and off the internet. ■

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